1.4 Studying Visual Art and your Future

A resource for students in Year 10, and their parents

Studying Visual Art in Years 11 and 12 will contribute to your employability skills. The Queensland Visual Art Syllabus is a dynamic curriculum intrinsically connected to the 21st century skills that drive the ways we think, work and respond to the world. These are the skills and attributes of productive 21st century citizens who engage with and embrace rapid change. The Visual Art classroom is a place for creativity, problem-solving and innovative ideas. Studying Visual Art will assist you to:

- become a critical thinker by analysing, solving problems, making decisions, justifying, reflecting, evaluating and thinking flexibly
- become a creative thinker through experiences that require experimentation, innovation, initiative, curiosity and imagination to generate new ideas, identify alternatives and make new links
- develop communication skills as you implement ideas and create using visual, written and spoken language and expressive forms as an artist and interpret meaning in artworks as an audience
- recognise the value of diverse perspectives and the role of visual art in communities by exploring collaborative processes of artists and audiences
- develop personal and social skills as you explore diverse art practices, traditions and cultures of others; evaluate your own reactions, cultural awareness and flexibility; seek opportunities to engage with and realise art forms that employ traditional art media, techniques and processes; and explore art that incorporates constantly evolving information and communication technologies.

"…employers are not only signalling demand for creativity, critical thinking, problem solving and skills relating to the development and use of technology, but are placing more and more emphasis on interpersonal and socio-emotional skills. The latter include the ability to collaborate, coordinate and communicate effectively with others".

The World Economic Forum, 2023, *Defining Education 4.0: A Taxonomy for the Future of Learning* Source https://www3.weforum.org/docs/WEF_Defining_Education_4.0_2023.pdf

Regardless of your career aspirations, choosing the subjects you enjoy and experience success in, contributes to success in your senior secondary studies.

Read more about 21st century skills and how they relate to Queensland's senior curriculum.

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Past student testimonies

Visual Art broadens your skills and presents many possibilities for your future. The following testimonies of past Visual Art students explain how the subject has prepared them for diverse careers. The 21st century skills you learn in Visual Art are transferable and valued **in diverse fields such as science, medicine, law, academia, architecture and engineering.**

Law

Anna Reynolds lawyer

"I've been working in climate change litigation for the past four years, with a particular focus on preventing the approval of new and extended coal mines. At its core, being a good lawyer is about being an effective communicator and a good storyteller. Visual Art was my favourite subject during high school. I didn't think of myself as particularly gifted at visual languages, but to me, the subject was about the process of art-making. It gave me the opportunity to think conceptually about ideas, research widely, push the limits of the idea and find creative ways to communicate an outcome. The skills I developed by actively engaging in this process are the same skills I call on as a lawyer: persuasively and effectively communicating complex and nuanced scientific and legal concepts, and humanising those concepts through story-telling."

Charlotte Watson lawyer

"My favourite and highest-ranked subject was Visual Art. I now work as a lawyer and value the opportunity I had to learn and develop skills and knowledge in Visual Art. It taught me different ways of looking at objects and concepts, and to critically consider multiple perspectives, including cultural and historical contexts. I also developed skills to plan, execute and manage individual projects towards my assessment portfolio.
These skills are directly transferable to my career as a lawyer where I am required to have a high degree of focus, grasp of critical thinking and clear communication. While preparing a legal document, I need to think about how different types of readers will understand and interpret it based on the contents and the overall visual design. More and more, the legal industry is looking for creative ways to understand problems and communicate ideas, so a background in creative problem solving is very useful. More directly, a knowledge of design and image principles assists in advising on specific areas of law including intellectual property law surrounding trademarks, logos and designs."
Charlotte's artwork featured on the cover of Creative Inquiry, first edition (page 54, figure 5.5 and page 58).

In a legal career the traits of critical and creative thinking, clear communicating and empathy are highly valued.

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Kathleen Stonehouse lawyer

"I have worked for over 9 years as a lawyer in Queensland after completing a Bachelor of Media and Communication and Bachelor of Laws at university. In senior school I chose to study Visual Art and I thoroughly enjoyed it. Studying Visual Art helped me to 'read' and understand the language of art and to connect with visual stories, from the personal stories of artists to stories of various cultures and nationalities, and stories that touch all of humanity. These stories stirred conviction and inspired courage in me, as well as growing my compassion for others. Visual Art helped to develop my critical thinking, reasoning, and writing skills, and it challenged me to explore and creatively express my own ideas.
I now work as a lawyer mostly in the fields of Wills and estates and charity law, where it is essential that I learn and empathise with each client's story, critically analyse the scenario and applicable law, and clearly communicate the options, the strategy, and the outcomes with the client. I can see that studying Visual Art was a vital part of my education, character formation, and early professional development. I heartily recommend Visual Art to students with any interest or enjoyment in art, as it is fertile ground for personal and professional growth."

Science

Specimen of longsnout seahorse.

"When I told my careers advisor at school that I wanted to study science at university, she instantly told me to drop Visual Art because I wouldn't need it.
I did Visual Art until the end of Grade 12"

Rowan Carew marine biologist

"I have always loved the ocean. The weird and wonderful creatures under the waves fascinated me and led to my interest in science. I was never particularly successful at Maths or Chemistry, but I made up for it with my creativity and skills in Visual Art. When I told my careers advisor at school that I wanted to study science at university, she instantly told me to drop Visual Art because I wouldn't need it. I did Visual Art until the end of Grade 12. I worked hard at my university studies; completing bridging maths and chemistry courses before starting a Bachelor of Science. I am now continuing my research into seahorse vision through a PhD (Doctor of Philosophy) at the University of Queensland. Studying an animal's visual system is a complex problem because they see the world completely differently. Seahorses have a very different retinal structure to humans and

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may even be able to see colours that we can't. How do seahorses communicate visually with each other? How do different visual environments affect their ability to see?
How do they use their visual system to catch their prey? Answering these questions requires a scientist to use their imagination and see the world from a different perspective. This skill is a central part of Visual Art, taught through subject matter such as Surrealism, realism, and photography, but is hardly ever taught in science.
Skills like slow and methodical patience and attention to detail (which are essential for art) allowed me to discover aspects of the seahorse visual system which haven't been investigated before, simply due to the sheer time and patience the procedure required.
As a scientist (especially in university) you are encouraged to "think outside the box" and see things from a different perspective. But for me, it was studying Visual Art that taught me how.''

Lilly Dawson marine biology student

"In senior school my four electives were Visual Art, Biology, Marine Science, and Chemistry. Visual Art was a necessary creative outlet for me whilst I pursued my passion for science. Throughout school, I discovered that these two fields were not mutually exclusive, but instead greatly benefitted one another. The ability to observe and record details in my artwork aided my capability of observing and analysing data and trends in science. The critical thinking required to interpret and make hypotheses developed this skill for critically analysing art works. Importantly, Visual Art continuously used my imagination which enabled me to think outside of the box and persist in questioning what we know in science.

Today, I am pursuing a career in marine biology utilising the skills learnt in my Visual Art classes every day. A key element in science is communication and relaying findings to the general public. A great way to do this is through art. Art is captivating and makes people stop, think, and reflect. These are things scientists want people to do with their findings so not only are skills transferable, but art has a huge part to play in science communication."

Marine biologists require patience, observation skills, imagination, critical and creative thinking to research, monitor and solve environmental problems such as thermal stress on reef systems.

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Humanities research

Amelia Hine researcher in human geography

"The skills I learnt in high school Visual Art are integral to my role as an early career academic in the field of human geography. The freedom to imagine solutions to artistic briefs in art imbued in me not only the capacity to problem-solve using progressive logic to work through complex ideas, but also taught me independence in decision-making and action.

These skills have allowed me to find new angles to understanding and analyse real world controversies such as coal mine closures and approvals, and to formulate new approaches for interpreting and communicating stakeholder perspectives.

This is the core challenge for academics, to find the gaps in existing knowledge and to create new knowledge to fill them. Visual Art also fostered the emergence of my key skillset, which is to analyse and synthesise vast, disconnected stores of information into a single compelling narrative.

Written assignments in Visual Art were particularly formative, requiring careful analytical work to deconstruct artworks and innovative problem-solving to find connecting themes across them. This process of analysis and finding connections is one that I use daily in my work, and I believe is the single most critical skill I learnt in high school."

Human geographers study the interaction between humans and the surface of the earth, such as our current reliance on coal mines for employment and as sources of power. Geopraphers analyse how communities are impacted by the earth and how the earth impacts people.

"These skills have allowed me to find new angles to understanding and analyse real world controversies such as coal mine closures and approvals, and to formulate new approaches for interpreting and communicating stakeholder perspectives."

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Health care

A doctor views CT scans in an emergency room at a hospital. Well-developed observation skills are crucial to a career in medicine. Johns Hopkins University in the USA is one university that has incorporated various Visual Art based electives for medical students, to support the development of observation skills and empathy in medical practitioners.

Tori (Victoria) Berquist physician, industry consultant, policy academic and board director

“I'm passionate about innovation and policy to achieve better outcomes and improve health equity. My work focuses on solving challenging issues facing public and private sectors of the healthcare industry in the US, Asia and Oceania. I research and write on financing, regulation and incentives in healthcare. When I think of high school, I think of my favourite subject, Visual Art. While I ended up studying medicine then going on to other pursuits in business and policy, Art provided me with the crucial skills to understand and exercise my creativity, self-expression, and flexibility. I use Art to think, communicate, problem solve and centre my mind.

In the business world, I use my understanding of the power of visual expression, colour, and design to convey stories to my clients that help them come to grips with the next major move for them. In the policy world, I think about changes to be made as if on a canvas, considering how the moving parts of society will be impacted by what is outlined on a page. And in my personal life, I use Art as a salve to make sense of everything going on around me and create space through creativity to think about what comes next. I’ll forever be grateful to Art in school as the space that enabled me to be successful in everything else that I did. It continues to serve that function in my life today.”

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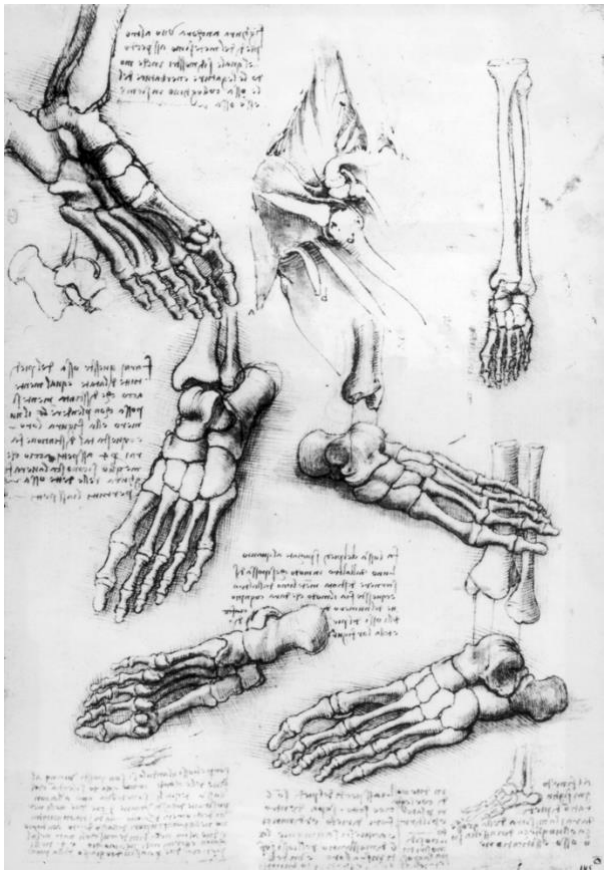
A physiotherapist attends to an injured player in a New Zealand All Blacks training session.



Leonardo da Vinci (1452 - 1519) studied anatomy and recorded his observations in great detail. Here is a detail from one of da Vinci's sketchbooks: *Bones of the Foot and Shoulder*, pen and brown ink with wash over black chalk. Circa 1509.

Harry Collier physiotherapist

"Throughout my Year 11 and 12 studies at Ashgrove, I had every intention of pursuing a health-related field and thus studied Maths B, Maths C and Physics. However, I made a great decision to continue studying Visual Art alongside these subjects.

Visual Art allowed me time in my day to think creatively and express myself in different ways – mainly through painting which was my favourite medium. The assignment-based work broadened my worldview as I learnt about historical artists and famous artworks.

I continued to utilise the skills I learnt in Visual Art in university (where I studied a Bachelor of Exercise Science and a Master of Physiotherapy)"

"When learning anatomy, I would draw in detail the relevant bones and muscles and label them to help me memorise the content, and I found this to be really effective."

Helen Pynor used bone from her own body in her sculpture, *Habitation*, 2021.

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Architecture

Brisbane artist Phoebe Paradise's *Foundation*, 2023, an outdoor installation, comprises laser-cut and welded aluminium houses of various sizes. It comments on Queensland architecture and floods. Photography and videography by Joey Bailey. Image courtesy of the artist.

Leonor Gausachs architect

"I studied Visual Art at St Peter's Lutheran College. I now practise as an architecture graduate at Group GSA. Visual Art was an essential subject in developing the skills necessary for my career. Without relying on words, I learned the language of composition, colour, texture and visual sequence. Keeping a visual diary taught me about experimentation and its documentation and I continue to use these skills in practice as evidence of the labour behind producing a design. This is core to negotiating fees with clients and justifying the value of creativity.

Knowledge of how to use different art media was of great use in university and now a point of difference as a professional designer. I'm not married to a computer program to communicate because I had already developed a drawing style to produce presentation-quality sketches. I already knew how to work with clay to explore forms other than square buildings. I already knew how to photograph models and edit photos. I'd already practiced visually descriptive language. I'd already curated an exhibition with aesthetic and conceptual cohesiveness.

Studying Visual Art at school shaped my mind to formulate responses using research in history, current affairs and the future potential of humanity. Not only did I learn how to translate the effect of external stimuli into a visual narrative but also how to evoke thought, reactions and emotions in other people.

The skills I acquired through Visual Art are my point of difference within my architecture office. I now have the opportunity to be heavily involved in the design process of buildings early in my career. I'm valued for my ability to generate ideas, my refined aesthetics and visual communication. My participation is requested for projects across different offices within the company to generate momentum at the inception of a project, make diagrams, curate presentations, experiment with massing, and letting my imagination run wild."

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Architect using a digital measuring device to measure the line length on an architectural drawing.

"While all the subjects helped me prepare for my architectural studies & career, the processes and critical thinking you undertake in Visual Art are what have stuck as they are easily transferable across disciplines, particularly in the case of design."

David de Roquefeuil architect

"Throughout my senior years at Marist, I was set on the idea that I would study architecture (or some form of design) at university and with this in mind I undertook subjects such as visual arts, graphics, design, & geography. While all the subjects helped me prepare for my architectural studies & career, the processes and critical thinking you undertake in Visual Art are what have stuck as they are easily transferable across disciplines, particularly in the case of design.
The idea of an iterative process may be foreign to some disciplines however it is paramount in art just as much as it is in design. In architecture the process of designing often means that we have to take a few steps back to be able to move forwards. The process is certainly not linear, and that's what Visual Art taught me."

Doh Ho Suh's *Staircase – V,* 2008, made of polyester and stainless steel, challenges our understanding of the solidity of architecture.

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